MOVEMENT

Returning to activity after a heart event

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Patient education. Follow your healthcare team’s advice.

How can you return to activity safely?

Returning to activity after a heart event or surgery can feel uncertain. Cardiac rehabilitation helps you rebuild activity with guidance from a healthcare team. Your exercise plan should fit your condition, treatment, and abilities. Ask your team before starting, restarting, or increasing exercise. [1,4]

Build gradually

Your plan may include walking or another aerobic activity, strength work, and flexibility exercises. Each has a different purpose. Aerobic movement supports cardiovascular fitness, strength work helps muscles, and stretching supports flexibility. General activity targets are not a starting prescription for every patient. Follow the amount, pace, and progression your team recommends, especially after recent surgery or a hospital stay. [1,2,3,5]

Prepare and finish with care

Warm-up and cool-down periods help your breathing and heart rate change gradually. Ask the team how these should fit into your session. Wear suitable shoes and comfortable clothes. If you have restrictions on fluids, follow those instructions rather than general advice to drink more water. After surgery, confirm any limits on lifting, pushing, pulling, and other movements. [1]

Learn your warning signs

Stop activity if you develop chest discomfort, unusual breathlessness, dizziness, or a fast or uneven heartbeat. Get medical advice promptly. New or persistent chest pressure, fainting, severe breathing difficulty, or symptoms suggesting a heart attack need emergency assessment. Do not try to finish the session first. Your team should explain what symptoms to watch for and what action to take. [1]

Make the plan easy to follow

Ask for written instructions before leaving your appointment. You might ask: How long should I walk? What pace should I use? When should I rest? What should I do if I miss a session? Keep the answers where you can see them. A clear plan is easier to follow and share with your family.

Notice progress without competing

Use a simple notebook to record the activity your team approved, how long you did it, and how you felt. Include questions about discomfort or fatigue. Share the notes at your next visit. Progress is personal. Avoid copying online challenges or comparing your recovery with another patient. Your team can help interpret changes and decide whether your plan needs adjustment.

Think about your surroundings

Before an approved walk, consider where you will rest and how you will get help if needed. Ask your team about outdoor activity in hot weather and about uneven surfaces or stairs. Tell them if transport, balance, joint pain, or fear of falling makes movement difficult. These details help turn broad advice into a routine you can follow.

Keep the conversation open

Report changes in your symptoms before the next exercise session. If your plan is unclear or too difficult, tell your team. Ask for written instructions and a contact for questions between appointments.

References

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2. National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute. (n.d.). Get regular physical activity. https://www.nhlbi.nih.gov/health/heart-healthy-living/physical-activity

3. National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute. (n.d.). Physical activity benefits. https://www.nhlbi.nih.gov/health/heart/physical-activity/benefits

4. MedlinePlus. (n.d.). Being active when you have heart disease. https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000094.htm

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Cardiac Rehabilitation Unit
Cardiac Center · Bicol Medical Center
3rd Floor, 5-Storey Building · BMC Road, Concepcion Pequeña
Naga City, Camarines Sur 4400
(+63) 917-155-7163 · bmccardiaccenter@gmail.com
Ask about the program and appointment arrangements.
https://jusanmisolas.github.io/bmccare/